Bhakti and Other Important Religious Movements

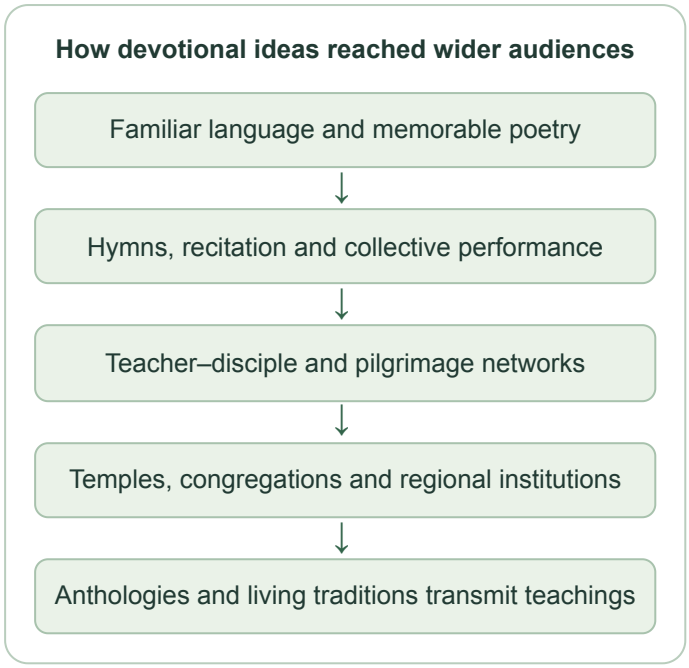
1. Bhakti: the central idea

Bhakti = devoted love for the Divine. Personal devotion, grace and surrender offered accessible ways to seek liberation; expressions differed across regions, communities and philosophical schools.

- Earlier devotional strands appear in Sanskrit and other traditions; image worship, Puranic religion and temple patronage expanded over time. Gupta-period patronage was important, but did not invent all Vishnu worship.
- Tamil poet-saints made devotion a powerful public tradition from about the **sixth century CE**. Northern and regional movements flourished particularly during the **twelfth–seventeenth centuries**.
- Buddhism/Jainism formed part of the earlier religious setting; **Mahayana did not originate with the Buddha in the sixth century BCE**. Avalokiteshvara is a bodhisattva, not simply a name for the Buddha's “gracious form”.
- **Common themes, not universal rules:** heartfelt devotion over empty formalism; spiritual guidance; singing and remembrance; vernacular expression; dignity and fellowship.
- Not all Bhakti saints rejected images, temples, Vedic authority, caste institutions or pilgrimage. **Religious accessibility did not automatically abolish social inequality.**

Why did movements spread?

Factor	Contribution
Religious resources	Tamil hymns, Vaishnava/Shaiva traditions, Puranas, Vedanta and Nath practices offered varied vocabularies.
Social criticism	Some saints challenged caste exclusion, ritual authority and elite privilege.
Economic change	Growing towns, artisanal activity and mobility in the thirteenth–fourteenth centuries widened audiences; this is one historical explanation, not a single proven cause.
Cultural exchange	Bhakti and Sufi communities interacted in a shared social world; affinities do not mean Bhakti began solely as an Islamic influence.
Language and performance	Poetry, oral transmission, gatherings and music carried ideas beyond Sanskrit-trained elites.
Institutions and patronage	Temples, mathas, panths, congregations and royal/local support helped preserve and spread teachings.



2. South India: Alvars and Nayanars

Tradition	Devotion / people	Texts and significance
12 Alvars	Vishnu; Periyalvar, **Andal**, Nammalvar, Tondaradippodi and others.	**Nalayira Divya Prabandham**: approximately 4,000 Tamil hymns, assembled by about the tenth century; revered as the **Tamil Veda**.
63 Nayanars	Shiva; Appar, Sambandar, Sundarar, **Karaikkal Ammaiyar** and others.	**Tevaram**: hymns of Appar, Sambandar and Sundarar; **Tiruvachakam**: associated with Manikkavachakar in the wider Tamil Shaiva canon.

- Flourished under **Pallavas, Pandyas and Cholas**; temples and rulers supported devotional activity.
- Saints came from **diverse social backgrounds**, including Brahmins, artisans and marginalised communities—not uniformly from one caste group.
- **Andal:** woman Alvar, intense Vishnu devotion; **Karaikkal Ammaiyar:** woman Shaiva saint, ascetic imagery. **Manikkavachakar:** divine grace and surrender in Tamil poetry.
- Some hymns polemicised against Jains/Buddhists; competition for patronage mattered. Calling those religions simply “fatalistic” misrepresents their doctrines.
- **Limit:** spiritual inclusion and participation coexisted with temples, ritual authority and continuing caste disabilities. Neither “complete social revolution” nor “no challenge at all” captures every tradition.

3. Saguna and Nirguna: compare carefully

Dimension	Saguna	Nirguna
Divine conception	God with attributes/form; often Rama, Krishna or Shiva.	Divine beyond material form and attributes.
Examples	Tulsidas, Surdas, Mirabai, Chaitanya.	Kabir and Guru Nanak are commonly placed in this comparative category.

Dimension	Saguna	Nirguna
Worship	Personal deity, loving service, hymns; images/temples may matter.	Remembrance of the Name, inward experience and criticism of external formalism.
Social positions	Varied: devotional inclusion could coexist with hierarchy.	Often sharper criticism of caste distinctions and priestly claims; historical outcomes still varied.

Shared: devotion, guidance, accessible poetry, ethical concerns and fellowship. **Monotheism is not exclusive to Nirguna**, and "Saguna = every saint defended caste" is too sweeping. Sikhism developed a distinct religious tradition; the comparison does not reduce it to a Hindu sect.

4. Philosophers: doctrine, relation and route

Thinker / conventional dates	School	Main relation / path
Shankara, c.788–820	**Advaita**: non-dualism.	Brahman is ultimate reality; ignorance produces mistaken identification. Liberating knowledge is central. The empirical world is not absolutely independent; "unreal" does not mean ordinary experience never occurs.
Ramanuja, traditional 1017–1137	**Vishishtadvaita**: qualified non-dualism.	Brahman/Narayana is personal; souls and matter are real, dependent modes, often explained through **body–soul** relation. Bhakti, grace and **prapatti** (surrender).
Madhva, traditional 1238–1317	**Dvaita**: dualism.	Vishnu, individual souls and matter are really distinct; souls/world depend on God. Difference does **not** mean "no relationship whatsoever".
Nimbarka, dating disputed	**Dvaitadvaita / bhedabheda**.	Difference and non-difference; souls/world distinct yet dependent on Brahman. Radha–Krishna devotion and grace. Not an Akbar contemporary.
Vallabhacharya, 1479–1531	**Shuddhadvaita**: pure non-dualism.	World is a real manifestation of Brahman; **Pushtimarg**, the path of grace, emphasises loving **seva** to Krishna/Shrinathji. Not a doctrine of two independent ultimate realities.

Mnemonic: Shankara—one; Ramanuja—qualified unity; Madhva—real difference; Nimbarka—difference/non-difference; Vallabha—pure unity and grace.

Texts, institutions and places

- **Shankara:** Kaladi, Kerala; commentaries on **Brahma Sutras, principal Upanishads and Bhagavad Gita**; *Upadeshasahasri*. *Vivekachudamani* and *Bhaja Govindam* are traditionally attributed; authorship of some attributed works is debated. Four mathas associated by tradition: **Sringeri, Dwarka, Puri and Jyotirmath** in the Badrinath region.
- **Advaita analogy:** a rope mistaken for a snake → knowledge removes the error; it does not physically destroy a real snake.
- **Ramanuja:** Sriperumbudur, Tamil region; Alvar/Sri Vaishnava background; **Sri Bhashya, Vedanta Dipa, Gita Bhashya, Vedantasara**. Devotional access widened, while Vedic/social distinctions did not simply vanish.
- **Madhva:** Karnataka/Udupi; associated with **Brahma sampradaya** in traditional Vaishnava classification.

- **Nimbarka:** Radha–Krishna; **Sanaka/Kumara sampradaya**. Sun–ray analogy recalls relatedness and distinction; biography/chronology remain uncertain.
- **Vallabha:** traditionally born at **Champaranya near Raipur**, not Banaras; Telugu family background, later activity in north/west India. Associated with **Rudra sampradaya**, whose earlier lineage is linked to Vishnusvamin; do not make Vallabha its original founder. Chhattisgarh Tourism.

5. Regional saints: names, works and exam cues

Karnataka, Assam and eastern India

Saint	Recall
Basavanna, twelfth century	Karnataka; minister associated with Kalachuri **Bijjala**, ruling c.1157–1167. Kannada **vachanas**; Lingayat/Virashaiva reform context; opposition to caste exclusion and gender barriers; dignity of work and spiritual experience.
Basavanna's community	**Anubhava Mantapa**: remembered forum of Sharanas for discussion. “First parliament” is a modern analogy, not proof of a modern elected legislature. **Arivu–Achara–Anubhava:** knowledge, conduct, experience.
Lingayat practice	Personal **ishtalinga**, Shiva devotion; challenges to pollution/rebirth hierarchy; widow remarriage and post-puberty marriage supported in the reform tradition; burial rather than normative Brahmanical cremation. Practices/identities vary.
Vidyapati, c.1352–1448	Maithili poet; Shiva devotion and the **Ugna** tradition; also celebrated for Radha–Krishna love poetry.
Shankaradeva, 1449–1568	Assam/Brahmaputra valley and Koch region; Vishnu–Krishna devotion, **Ekasarana/Mahapurushiya** tradition; Assamese poetry and drama; **satras** and **namghars**. Satras = monastic institutions; namghars = congregational prayer/recitation halls.
Jayadeva, twelfth century	*Gita Govinda*: Radha–Krishna love; important devotional/literary background to eastern Vaishnavism.
Chaitanya, 1486–1533	Bengal–Odisha; Krishna devotion, ecstatic **sankirtan**, love and accessible collective worship; Haridas illustrates participation across inherited religious boundaries.
Chaitanya tradition	Six Goswamis of Vrindavan systematised devotional traditions; **Krishnadas Kaviraj—Chaitanya Charitamrita**. Associated with **achintya-bhedabheda** in Gaudiya tradition, not simply identical to Madhva's Dvaita. Social hierarchies persisted despite devotional inclusion.
Narsinh Mehta, c.1414–1481	Gujarat; Radha–Krishna songs; **Vaishnava Jan To** associated with him, later cherished by Gandhi; compassion is the moral cue.
Annamacharya, 1408–1503	Telugu poet/composer; **Venkateshwara of Tirumala**, sankirtanas; dignity beyond caste exclusion.
Tyagaraja, 1767–1847	Carnatic composer, primarily Telugu **Rama** devotion; **Pancharatna Kritis**, associated with Nata, Gaula, Arabhi, Varali and Sri ragas. Music as devotion; not Annamacharya's contemporary.

Carnatic Trinity: Tyagaraja, Muthuswami Dikshitar, Syama Sastri. The chapter's map also names **Purandaradasa** in the Karnataka devotional/music tradition. Do not confuse the Maharashtra saint Samarth Ramdas with the Telugu composer **Bhadrachala Ramadasu**.

Maharashtra: Vitthala and the Varkari tradition

Centre: Pandharpur, Vitthala/Vithoba, associated with Krishna; Marathi poetry, kirtan and pilgrimage. Bhagavata and Nath traditions contributed to its religious environment.

Saint / conventional dates	Works and contribution
Jnaneshwar/Dnyaneshwar, 1275–1296	**Jnaneshwari**, Marathi Bhagavad Gita commentary; *Amritanubhava*, *Haripath*, abhang tradition; accessible spiritual teaching.
Namdev, c.1270–1350	Marathi **abhangs**, Vitthala devotion, community singing; hymns in **Guru Granth Sahib**. Tailor association in tradition; conversion/bandit stories are hagiography.
Eknath, c.1533–1599	Marathi religious literature; *Bhavarth Ramayan*, **bharuds**, recension of *Jnaneshwari*. Householder devotion; criticism of social exclusion.
Tukaram, c.1608–1649/50	Marathi **abhangs**, preserved in the *Gatha*; Vitthala, kirtan, compassion, forgiveness and criticism of hypocrisy. An abhanga is not simply a Hindi **doha**. He lived after Eknath's death.
Samarth Ramdas, 1608–1681	Rama/Hanuman devotion; **Dasbodh, Manache Shlok, Karunashtakas**; spiritual discipline and action. His precise relationship with Shivaji is debated; do not make all later guru-legends settled fact.

- **Varkari:** Vitthala-centred devotional/pilgrimage tradition; **Dharkari** is a textbook label linked to Ramdas's active/heroic devotional emphasis. “Emotional versus rational” is a schematic contrast, not a fixed character judgement.
- Social breadth is illustrated by saints associated with diverse occupations: **Sena—barber; Savata—gardener; Gora—potter; Narhari—goldsmith; Chokhamela—marginalised Mahar background; Janabai—domestic work; Kanhopatra—performer**. They were not all necessarily Namdev's simultaneous companions.
- **Karmamela**, Chokhamela's son: devotional poetry confronts humiliation and exclusion. Tukaram's poetry joins devotion with solidarity with the distressed; spirituality did not erase the continuing reality of caste.

Northern devotional currents

Saint / period	Key teachings and texts
Ramananda, broadly fourteenth–fifteenth centuries	North Indian Rama–Sita devotion; vernacular teaching; Ramanandi tradition; often presented as a link with southern Sri Vaishnavism. Exact dates and disciple lists are contested; not Ramanuja's direct contemporary disciple.
Kabir, fifteenth–early sixteenth century	Weaver-associated Banaras tradition; formless Divine, **Ram/Rahim** beyond sectarian claims; criticised caste, untouchability, empty ritual and hypocrisy; inward sincerity over book learning alone.
Kabir's corpus	**Bijak**, verses in Guru Granth Sahib and other collections; **ulatbansi** = paradoxical/upside-down expression; later **Kabir Panth**. Birth and initiation stories are traditions, not securely documented biography.
Ravidas/Raidas, fifteenth–sixteenth centuries	Leather-working association; devotion and dignity beyond caste; hymns in Guru Granth Sahib. Some traditions link him to Mirabai.
Dadu Dayal, 1544–1603	Gujarat origins in tradition; Rajasthan activity; Nirguna devotion, **nipakh** (non-sectarian outlook); **Dadu Panth** and **thambas**. **Kabir cannot have been his disciple:** Kabir belonged to an earlier generation.

Saint / period	Key teachings and texts
Tulsidas, sixteenth–early seventeenth centuries	**Ramcharitmanas in Awadhi**; Rama devotion; spiritual accessibility alongside inherited social ideals.
Surdas, fifteenth–sixteenth centuries	Braj Krishna poetry: **Sursagar, Sursaravali, Sahitya Lahari**; associated with the Vallabha tradition. Exact life dates vary.
Mirabai, fifteenth–sixteenth centuries	Krishna as divine beloved; bhajans, Rajput/Mewar context, resistance to prescribed familial roles; biography and dates largely mediated through later traditions.

Ramananda's traditional disciple lists include **Kabir, Ravidas, Sena, Sadhana (butcher), Dhanna (peasant), Pipa (Rajput ruler)** and others; **Guru Nanak is not securely established as his direct disciple**. Nabhadas/Tulsidas and Kabir are often used to illustrate different later tendencies, not a uniform organisation under one founder.

Radha-Vallabha tradition: Hit Harivansh, sixteenth century; do not memorise the chapter's unsupported 1585 founding date as settled.

6. Women, inclusion and limits

Woman saint	Recall
Andal	Tamil Vishnu devotion; woman Alvar.
Karaikkal Ammaiyar	Tamil Shiva devotion and ascetic identity.
Akka Mahadevi, twelfth century	Karnataka vachanas; Shiva as **Chennamallikarjuna**; challenge to bodily/social conventions.
Janabai, thirteenth–fourteenth centuries	Maharashtra; Namdev household tradition; everyday labour and caste/gender barriers enter devotional poetry.
Mirabai	Krishna devotion asserts spiritual agency beyond expected royal/household roles.
Bahinabai, seventeenth century	Marathi devotional abhangs; tensions between household duties and spiritual life. Distinguish her from the later modern Marathi poet Bahinabai Chaudhari.

- Poetry made domestic labour, family tension, absence and longing spiritually meaningful. Some renounced household roles; others practised devotion within them.
- Inclusion widened women's expressive space, but acceptance often required struggle in male-dominated institutions; the divine-husband idiom could both challenge and reuse patriarchal imagery.
- **Assessment:** new voices and spiritual dignity mattered; neither gender hierarchy nor caste exclusion disappeared uniformly.

7. Sufism: inward discipline within Islam

Sufism encompasses Islamic mystical/devotional traditions concerned with purifying the self, love, remembrance and nearness to God. **Suf = wool**, recalling early ascetic clothing; “purity” is an associated ideal, not the literal translation of that root.

- Early ascetic/mystical figures include **Rabia al-Adawiyya**, **Bayazid Bistami** and **Junayd**; early traditions developed from the eighth century, with major literature/institutions by the eleventh–twelfth centuries.
- **Ali Hujwiri**, eleventh century, Lahore: **Kashf al-Mahjub**, a Persian Sufi treatise.

- Spiritual training, repentance, prayer, charity, fasting and ethical conduct mattered. Love of God could be expressed through service to people; not every order held identical views on music, rulers or legal practice.
- **Fana** = effacement of the ego; **ishq** = intense divine love; **ruh** = spirit/soul; **qurb** = nearness. **Hulul** (indwelling/incarnation language) was controversial and is not a universally accepted Sufi doctrine.



Essential glossary

Term	Correct recall
Silsila / tariqa	Chain/lineage or order; tariqa = spiritual path/method.
Pir / shaikh / murshid; murid	Spiritual guide; disciple. **Wali** = saint/friend of God, not simply “teacher”.
Khanqah	Hospice/lodge and centre of communal spiritual life; not the pir himself.
Dargah; ziyarat	Saint's shrine/tomb; visitation/pilgrimage.
Sama; qawwali; qaul	Devotional audition/listening; musical performance tradition; a form of devotional utterance/song associated with Chishti performance. Practices were contested.
Tauba; wara; zuhd	Repentance; scrupulous avoidance of the doubtful; renunciation/ascetic detachment.
Jud; faqr	Generosity; spiritual poverty/dependence on God.
Sabr; shukr	Patience/endurance; gratitude.
Khauf; tawakkul; rida	Fear/awe; trust in God; contented acceptance of God's will.
Ba-sharia; be-sharia	Labels for conformity to prescribed law and its perceived rejection/transgression; not an adequate explanation of every Sufi's beliefs.
Wahdat al-wujud	Unity of being, especially associated with Ibn Arabi's tradition; interpretations differ.

Qalandars, Madaris, Malangs and Haidaris are among ascetic groups discussed under the be-sharia category. Do not equate all Sufis with rejection of Islamic law.

8. Four major Sufi orders

Order	People / centres	Distinctive tendencies
Chishti	**Muinuddin Chishti—Ajmer**; Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki—Delhi; **Baba Farid—Punjab**; Nizamuddin Auliya and Nasiruddin Chiragh-i Delhi.	Love, service, hospitality, simple living; many leading shaikhs kept distance from courts; sama and vernacular interaction prominent.
Suhrawardi	Abu Najib/Shihabuddin Suhrawardi in the order's West Asian history; **Bahauddin Zakariya—Multan**.	More acceptance of property, grants and political contacts; religious learning with spiritual discipline; Punjab/Sindh.
Qadiri	**Abd al-Qadir al-Jilani—Baghdad**; later South Asian networks include Nimatullah/Jilani traditions, **Miyan Mir**, **Mulla Shah Badakhshi**.	Diverse devotional networks; Dara Shikoh and Jahanara associated with Qadiri teachers. Do not date the order's original founding to Mughal India.
Naqshbandi	**Bahauddin Naqshband—Central Asia**; **Baqi Billah introduced the order in India**, later **Ahmad Sirhindi (1564–1624)**.	Silent remembrance, strong stress on sharia and criticism of religious innovations; Sirhindi opposed aspects of Akbar-era accommodation. Not every later member held identical political views.

IGNOU on Naqshbandi history.

Chishti names and centres

- **Muinuddin Chishti, d.1236: Gharib Nawaz**, Ajmer; later pilgrimage and royal patronage, especially Akbar. **Chisht is in present-day Afghanistan**, not a village in Ajmer. Date of settling at Ajmer varies in accounts; do not confuse later patronage with the saint's lifetime.
- **Baba Farid, c.1175–1265/66:** Fariduddin Ganj-i Shakar; hymns in Guru Granth Sahib; ascetic discipline and distance from power.
- **Nizamuddin Auliya, 1238–1325:** compassion and service; discipline, purity, fasting, devotion and guidance. Kept distance from courts; tensions with some Delhi sultans.
- **Amir Khusrau**, Amir Hasan Sijzi and Ziauddin Barani belonged to his intellectual/devotional milieu. Khusrau is closely associated with Chishti musical traditions; do not ascribe every later musical form to one unqualified invention.
- **Nasiruddin Chiragh-i Delhi:** disciple/successor in Nizamuddin's lineage.
- **Burhanuddin Gharib:** important **fourteenth-century** Chishti expansion into the Deccan.
- **Muhammad Gesu Daraz/Banda Nawaz: Gulbarga/Kalaburagi**, not Bijapur.
- Later Naqshbandi figures **Shah Waliullah** and **Mirza Mazhar Jan-i Janan** illustrate variation; two rigid “conservative/liberal” labels cannot describe their full thought.

Impact and limits

Khanqah hospitality, service, shared shrine visitation, vernacular expression and music helped cultural exchange. Some Sufis influenced rulers; others avoided courtly dependence. **Contact did not erase doctrinal disagreement, political conflict or social hierarchy.** Bhakti–Sufi interactions contributed to shared literary/music cultures; Urdu's emergence had wider historical causes too.

9. Sikhism: teachings and institutions

Guru Nanak, 1469–1539

- Born at **Talwandi/Nankana Sahib**, now Pakistan; **Kartarpur on the Ravi** became a major community centre. Do not transfer Kartarpur's river location automatically to Talwandi.
- One eternal, formless Creator; **Naam**, ethical conduct, honest livelihood, service and equality; rejected empty ritual and inherited religious superiority.
- **Naam japna—remember the Divine; kirat karna—earn honestly; vand chhakna—share.** Householder life can be spiritual.
- **Guru–Shabad–Sangat:** teacher, sacred word and congregation; **langar** expresses shared fellowship. Mardana accompanied hymns on the **rabab**.

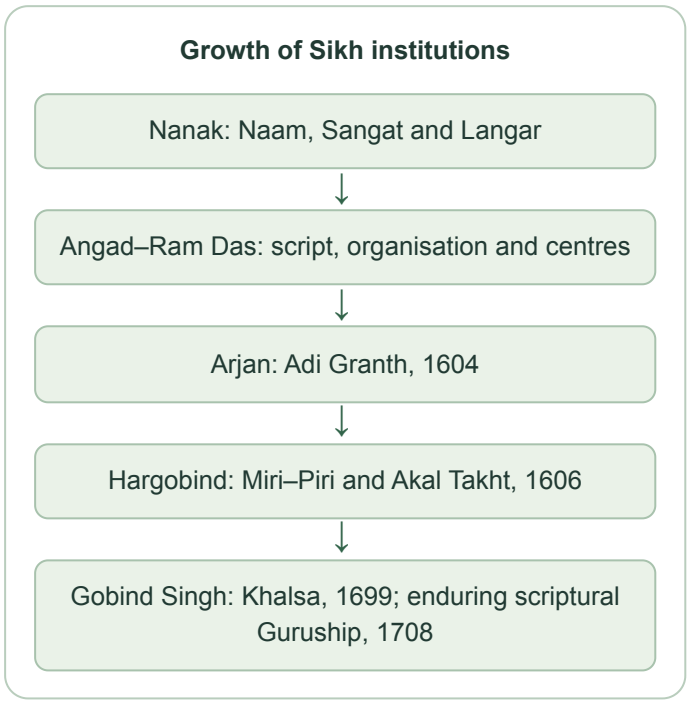
Ten Gurus: sequence and contributions

Nanak's dates below are his lifetime; subsequent ranges are periods of Guruship, not birth–death dates.

Guru / period	Recall
1. Nanak, 1469–1539 (life)	Founder; Naam, equality, honest work and sharing; congregational life/langar.
2. Angad, 1539–1552	Earlier name **Bhai Lehna**; standardised/popularised **Gurmukhi**; education, langar and **mall akhara**.
3. Amar Das, 1552–1574	**22 manjis**, women preachers/piri tradition; strengthened langar; opposition to sati/purdah and support for widow remarriage.
4. Ram Das, 1574–1581	**Ramdaspur/Amritsar**, conventionally **1577**; four **Lavan** hymns associated with Anand Karaj.
5. Arjan, 1581–1606	**Adi Granth compiled/installed at Harmandir Sahib, 1604**; developed Sikh centres; executed under Jahangir in **1606**, in the context of religious/political tensions including Khusrau.
6. Hargobind, 1606–1644	**Miri–Piri**, temporal/spiritual authority symbolised by **two swords**; **Akal Takht, 1606**; armed defence; later Kiratpur centre.
7. Har Rai, 1644–1661	Maintained community institutions; associated with assistance to Dara Shikoh; Mughal relations became strained.
8. Har Krishan, 1661–1664	Child Guru; remembered for service during illness in Delhi; died of smallpox in **1664**.
9. Tegh Bahadur, 1664–1675	Travel/preaching in eastern India; executed in Delhi under Aurangzeb, **1675**; **Sis Ganj Sahib** commemorates the site. Defence of religious conscience central to Sikh remembrance.
10. Gobind Singh, 1675–1708	Born Patna; **Khalsa at Anandpur, 1699**; Panj Pyare, initiation and collective discipline; **Guru Granth Sahib as enduring Guru, 1708**; died at Nanded.

- **Harmandir:** construction associated with Guru Arjan; tradition credits **Mian Mir** with laying the foundation. Land-acquisition and foundation narratives have variants; do not collapse town founding, shrine construction and installation of the Granth into one event. SGPC history.
- **Tegh Bahadur's succession:** SGPC records recognition in **1664**, rather than treating the source's 1665 as the sole date. SGPC.

- **Banda Singh Bahadur was commissioned by Guru Gobind Singh**, not Guru Tegh Bahadur, in **1708**. SGPC account.
- Khalsa initiation: **khande-di-pahul**, Panj Pyare; **five Ks—kesh, kangha, kara, kachhera, kirpan**. Guru and initiates reciprocally participated in initiation; shared discipline expressed equality and responsibility.
- **Dasam Granth:** corpus traditionally associated with Guru Gobind Singh; compilation/authorship of all its contents is debated. Distinguish it from **Adi Granth/Guru Granth Sahib**.



10. Exam traps and answer frameworks

Prelims recall

Question cue	Correct association / caution
Ramanuja	Devotion/grace and surrender, not logical argument alone.
Nimbarka–Akbar; Kabir–Sirhindi	Both proposed contemporaneity/influence claims are false.
Tyagaraja vs Annamacharya	Primarily Rama vs Venkateshwara; lived centuries apart.
Bijak; Pushtimarg	**Kabir; Vallabhacharya**, not Dadu and Madhva.
Babur's takeover, 1526	Guru Nanak was alive/preaching; Dadu and Tyagaraja were not.
Nagarjuna; anekantavada	Nagarjuna = Buddhist philosopher, not a medieval Bhakti proponent; anekantavada = Jainism.
Tukaram's Mughal contemporary	Jahangir among the supplied options; Shah Jahan also overlapped his life. Aurangzeb became emperor only in 1658.
Shankara → Ramanuja → Chaitanya	Correct relative order.
Sikh Guru/script	Angad = Gurmukhi; Arjan follows Ram Das; Gobind Singh commissions Banda.

Question cue	Correct association / caution
Namdev–Kabir–Ravidas–Sena	Tailor–weaver–cobbler–barber in conventional question associations.
Prem Vatika	**Raskhan**.
Chishti order's name	Chisht, Afghanistan; not Ajmer.

The supplied 2004 Sikh-Gurus MCQ has a defective option set: only statement 2 is correct, but no “2 only” choice is printed; its supplied answer is not adopted. The full question is preserved in the common bank for review without an asserted option answer.

Mains: build argument with examples and limits

- **2021 GS I:** nature and cultural contribution of Bhakti literature → devotional experience, vernacular/oral forms, social criticism, women, music and continuing traditions; explain limits to social change.
- **2018 GS I:** Chaitanya's reorientation → Krishna-centred emotional devotion, sankirtan, participation, Bengal–Odisha–Vrindavan networks, later theology; distinguish devotion from complete caste abolition.
- **2014 GS I:** claim that Sufis/medieval saints failed to modify society → weigh inclusion, vernacular culture and institutions against persistent hierarchy, political conflict and later sect formation; avoid an absolute yes/no.
- **2014 History optional:** Vaishnava saints and literature → Tamil Alvars; Jnaneshwari/Marathi abhangs; Braj Krishna poetry; Awadhi Rama literature; Bengali/Assamese/Telugu examples and their devotional differences.
- **2013 History optional:** historiography of Bhakti → spiritual/religious readings; social-protest and material explanations; vernacular/regional perspectives; caste/gender and critical textual approaches. Assess evidence, later hagiographies and the limits of treating many traditions as one movement.

Practice themes

Sikh Gurus' institutional contributions; Bhakti–Sufi interaction and its limits; Maharashtra's devotional literature. Practice questions remain separate from authenticated year-labelled PYQs; several printed practice options/keys are inconsistent and should not be memorised blindly.

11. Last-minute revision

Alvars—Vishnu; Nayanars—Shiva; Basavanna—vachanas; Shankaradeva—satras/namghars; Jnaneshwar—Marathi Gita; Kabir—Bijak; Nanak—Naam/work/sharing; Chishti—Ajmer/service; Naqshbandi—Baqi Billah/Sirhindi; Arjan—1604; Gobind Singh—1699/1708.